

Ethical Ambiguities of Our Emergent Digital World

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In this module, we approach the question of ethical AI from a more philosophical standpoint. We discuss three broad ethical questions: Does technology increase inequality? Does technology decrease human autonomy? Does technology provide a sense-making narrative?

Lecture Transcript

0:02 Good day everyone. My name is Piet Naudé, you will see my name on the screen a little bit later. And I am very honored to participate in this Artificial Intelligence: Global Perspectives ethics course. And I hope that my contribution, more philosophical, will find great interest among you as we think through some of the big issues. And for that, I'll just share my screen for a moment so that you can see the title of my presentation. I'll just go to the beginning.

0:40 Yeah, I chose as a title - Ethical Ambiguities of Our Emergent Digital World. I recorded this late in February, early March. You can see that I'm a professor of ethics at the Stellenbosch Business School in South Africa. In the background, there you can see the iconic Table Mountain. So perhaps at this point, just explaining a little bit about my personal academic focus. I'm a philosopher and theologian by training. I'm not a person that has been trained in computer science and technology. My academic focus is mostly on methodology of ethics, and also on the broader ethical questions of global justice, economic and otherwise. I come from an emerging market context, South Africa, which means that I view artificial intelligence and the digital revolution as it were from an emerging market perspective, which means we have far less lack of infrastructure than would be available in a mature economy.

1:52 For instance, in South Africa, specifically, we have big issues around stable electricity supply, bandwidth for access to the internet. Our institutions are still growing into the democratic ethos. And we have an extremely high unemployment rate that affects our thinking around what artificial intelligence and digitalization might do, for instance, to employment and the job market. And the core message of my lecture is that we should not blindly embrace the fantastic developments in artificial intelligence in the world, in fields like agriculture, in biology, in health care, in education, in business, because, I think, as an ethicist, one should, as it was, stand a little bit one step back and say, let us, look at the ambiguities of what's happening in the world. It's both a big chance, and also obviously a big risk.

3:04 And I am reminded of the very famous German philosopher Martin Heidegger, who already wrote in the early 1940s, that the purpose and use of technology are themselves not technological questions. So you cannot solve the question of what does AI do for us from a technological perspective, because technology simply does not answer that question. For that you need a wider perspective, from philosophy, and also from ethics. So there are

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three specific ethical questions I'd like to raise. The first one is does technology increase inequality? In short, the answer, yes, it can. Does technology decrease human autonomy? Absolutely, yes, that has certain implications. And does technology provide a new sense-making narrative? The answer to that is it tries, but I don't think it will be able to do so. So there you have it all, in a nutshell. But let's go into each of those in a little bit more detail.

4:12 We know from the famous French economist, Piketty's book *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, that income and capital inequality are the major sources of inequality in the world. At this point, I think one could add technology and say that the digital divide creates a situation where those that are in the revolution and sort of on the wave of AI technology move extremely fast, and those who are excluded from that, in whatever sense, will lag behind more and more so that the divide between those that are so-called technically and technologically enabled and those excluded or only partially included that gap becomes wider. And it might lead internally in countries but also among countries a greater inequality.

5:06 The point is that technology and AI increases your socioeconomic capabilities. And Harari, the very famous best selling author from Israel, a historian that speaks a lot about where the world is going in the 21st century, says that the link between artificial intelligence and biology can even lead to enhanced human capabilities. What is called 'speciation' that means you can get a different category of humans that have been enhanced through artificial intelligence that is different from what we would call the normal homosapiens, thereby increasing the inequality within our species. And this inequality is obviously related to access: Do I have access to the internet? Do I have stable electricity? Do I have devices that allow me that participation? Once I'm in, can I participate fully or am I marginalized? And then obviously, the question of distributive justice, the question of how unequally distributed is the access to artificial intelligence around the world?

6:13 And we know the answer to that is exceptionally unequal. It can also over time, obviously, develop in a more positive way. But at the moment, there is an issue around the distribution of access. So the big question around inequality is should we start to talk about digital rights as a general human rights so that probably the second order human rights, like the right to housing, the right to health care, the right to basic human education, primary education? May we then in future say, because of the pervasiveness and the power of technology, driven also by machine learning and artificial intelligence, may lead us to the point where we say to be excluded from that is to be less human. And therefore, we need to think very carefully whether we should not include in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, a second order right: the right to digital access. So the answer to the first question, does technology increase inequality? The answer to that is yes, it can. And obviously, one can reverse that if you use technology more wisely, and make sure that the inequality to access, participation and redistribution is lessened and not increased over time.

7:37 So the second question is, does technology decrease human autonomy? And here, I put on my philosophical hat. The famous French philosopher, René Descartes, already said that we are a thinking I, therefore, I think, therefore I am. The rational human individual is the basis of how we view the human person. Anthropology, Immanuel Kant, reinforces that by saying that knowledge is created not by merely the impression of empirical observation onto our mind. In fact, it is us who, in our mind, categorize knowledge, so we contribute to knowledge making. That means the individual as an enlightened individual is the one that create knowledge. And look at Feuerbach, also a German philosopher said, humans are enormously capable of creating even God because

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he says God is, in his view, an expression of the desires of the human person for attributes that we don't have like, omniscience. God knows everything we don't. Eternity, god lives forever, we don't. And in that sense, God not so much creates human beings as human beings create God.

9:02 All of that leads to a very important principle is that we cannot understand modern science, modern democracy or the rise of capitalism without understanding that that is only possible on the basis of the individual pursuing knowledge, expressing their vote in a democracy and as an entrepreneur is free to start a business. It comes down to the question of individual autonomy. Now, what happened with artificial intelligence and development in autonomous decision making system, whether it's weapons or cars, is that this center of decision making, the center of autonomy, is dispersed, so that human subjectivity no longer rests within the individual human person only, but is codetermined by the systems that we create in our technology.

9:58 So that notions, objectivity and decisions are no longer within our own full control. And in some cases, we've given complete control over to program technology where we don't even have to think anymore, the machine or the system will do it for us. Now, that's a wonderful advancement, but we must remember the moment that happens, and it has happened, and it is happening at the moment, you have a big ethical implication. And that is if you have diminished agency, if I am no longer the full master of my own decisions by appointing people through an AI HR system, for instance, I then also obviously can claim diminished responsibility. We see this clearly in the huge debates about so-called autonomous cars or autonomous driving. If it is true that the vehicle is programmed and is continually updated in that programming to become a very safe vehicle. If then something does go wrong, the question is then who carries the liability and responsibility? And that question exactly relates back to this. In normal circumstances it is very simple, who was the driver and that person is liable. In this case, the question is, I am no longer the driver, so my responsibility has been shifted to an AI system. And that asks serious questions of obviously, about the ethical capability that is linked to a decrease in human autonomy.

11:26 So the third, big ethical question, a very philosophical one, is does technology provide a sense-making narrative? And we all know that the power of artificial intelligence and technological innovations is that it continues to disrupt. That disruption is in fact built into the system. To disrupt the financial markets, you create a startup that works differently with client interfaces. So, this disruption is obviously a very positive thing, it creates creativity in the system, innovation in the system, but it as a social economic implication. I just simply quote here to express this disruption: "To be is to be updated, to be updated and to be subjected to the update". This whole idea of updating, updating, updating all the time is a continuous assumption. But the point is, we as human beings, homo sapiens can only live if we have fairly stable myths or narratives from which we make sense. And three of the modern systems that we have created to make meaning for us is liberalism, the idea of individual freedom. And as I just indicated, that has been severely eroded in terms of autonomy through technology. The idea of capitalism. And as we know, there has been huge problems now with capitalism. And for instance, climate change, capitalism and inequality – there are many people who start asking, and very serious questions, around whether the capitalist system in its new liberal form is in fact, the best system for us going forward if it leads to increasing inequality amongst nations and if each for instance, does not, is not able to reverse a fossil fuel based economy.

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13:34 And then obviously, religion. And there is a growing tendency in the world into different forms of spirituality, some of them very unhealthy, but there's also a crisis in traditional religion. For instance, the Catholic Church with the problems of child abuse and things like that people start asking can we trust the system? And that leads to a big problem for the human species and such. And that is a question: from what will I derive a sense-making narrative? The question whether technology can become that power is then in doubt, because if the primary nature of technology is continued disruptions implies that obviously, it does not provide a stable narrative from which we can derive meaning. So I think technology in itself, although it is hugely pervasive and although we already gained enormous benefits from that, I think it's at this point still unable to provide a sense-making narrative. So what we then find is disorientation, on a personal psychological level, but also on a social level. I just see how in my own life, in say in the university, how much technology has changed the way I work, has changed the way I process knowledge, and have changed the way I communicate that knowledge. Like I do, at this moment, this would not have been possible even 10 years ago.

15:02 And that is disoriented. I have to be retrained. I was stable, a professor that knows what he or she does. And suddenly, I don't know any more. So there is a certain disorientation that takes place. What then happens in the world: politically is a rise in nationalisms, because that provides certainty; in religion, is a rising fundamentalism, again, that provides certainty. And obviously, people then become much more perceptive to fake news because they grab any straw they can get, as it were, to provide them information around the world. And even as we should get to know, our social media, and traditional media outlets find it very, very difficult to provide the world with, one would call as much as possible, objective, and as much as possible, unbiased news. So we are in a very difficult phase, at this point in the development of sociologically and psychologically of our human species, because of the disruption of technology. It brings us huge benefits. But it also brings us huge uncertainties. So the answer to the third ethical question, does technology provide a sense-making narrative? My answer to that is at this point, not yet. And I am at the moment doubtful that it will, in fact, in the end, gain that authority and stability to provide a sense-making narrative for us going forward.

16:28 So the big question, and I conclude with this, is how do we view as it were the spectacles through which we view the rise of technology, of which artificial intelligence is an important part? This picture is taken in Sea point on the promenade in the city of Cape Town in South Africa. If you stand on this side of the spectacles, as it were, they're quite huge. As you can see a wonderful artist, we look into the sea, and we are looking towards Robben Island, the place where President Nelson Mandela was imprisoned for 27 years. And it reminds us to always look for freedom, for liberation, for ethicality, for a better human future. And I think this is what we should do as ethicists. We should look at the developments of artificial intelligence and technology and ask ourselves the question, how can we use the enormous power at our disposal to create a better world and a better human being?

17:27 So this is my contact details. And if you want to read a little bit more, I have just published a book with Springer. And in chapter six, I devoted the whole chapter to management education, and the ambiguity of embracing technology. So I hope you've enjoyed my more philosophical approach to the topic and I wish you well in your endeavors to broaden your knowledge. And I once again, thank the organizers for including me in this exciting venture. I hope to hear back from you. Thank you very much.